



A green star shines in a quiet museum case. Beside it, a cream star stays dull. Both sit under the same dark-looking lamp. "Is one full of tiny lights?" Little asks. Big leans closer. The two stars have left them a puzzle.



"A clue past the rainbow," Little says. Their search begins long ago. In 1801, Johann Ritter spread sunlight into a rainbow. Light-sensitive material darkened just beyond violet, where he could see no light. An unseen kind of light was there! Today we call it ultraviolet, or UV.



Another display tells of George Stokes. In 1852, he studied materials that took in light and gave out a different color. He called the glow fluorescence. A crystal gleams blue in the case. "Could our star be doing that?" Little wonders. The old discoveries offer a new clue.



Back at the stars, Little studies the black light. It gives out mostly UV-A, the ultraviolet near visible violet. Our eyes cannot see UV-A. A little visible violet makes the lamp look purple. "It isn't sending out darkness," Little says. "It's sending light we cannot see!"

WONDER DAILY

The light we cannot see.

The light we cannot see



One leaf. Six steps. A story that keeps going.

GRADE 2

Make a little book.

1. Print one-sided: US Letter, portrait, actual size / 100%. No fit. Headers/footers off.
2. Fold long edge to long edge; reopen. Fold short edge to short edge, then in half again. Open: eight boxes.
3. Cut only the solid center line across the middle two boxes. Keep the outer boxes joined.
4. Refold long edge to long edge, print outside. Push ends together to open a diamond, then a cross.
5. Wrap into a book with page 1 in front. Follow pages 1 to 8.



Pictures are simplified and not to scale. Look closely, wonder, and pause whenever you like.

The green star has a special coating: a fluorescent phosphor. It absorbs UV-A and quickly emits green light. Absorb means take in; emit means give out. That re-glow is fluorescence. The plain star lacks this coating. "Same shape, different material!" Little says. The glow comes from the star itself.

The museum lamp switches off. The green fluorescence stops almost at once. Little sketches a lamp, a star, and light coming out. "No tiny lights inside," Little says. "A material makes the re-glow." Big leaves room on the page. What other material might hold a clue?

